VILLAGER PRO

Win the Bid: How Commercial Production Actually Works

The Director's Playbook for Agency Work, Pricing, and Building a Sustainable Company

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This guide is written from real experience running a commercial production company. The stories and scenarios throughout are composite illustrations drawn from real industry experiences. Names, companies, and identifying details have been changed to protect confidentiality.

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SECTION ONE

How the Machine Works

The Commercial Production Ecosystem

> *The client names, company names, and identifying details in this book have been changed to protect confidentiality. The situations, numbers, and outcomes are real.*

The first time you get an RFP from a real agency, it feels like an arrival. Someone found you. A Fortune 500 brand is somewhere in the chain. There's a budget, a timeline, a script. And somewhere between reading the brief and asking "so what do I do with this?" you realize you don't fully know how this thing works. Not the whole thing. Not who the players are, what each of them wants, why money moves the way it does, or where you actually fit.

That confusion is expensive. You can't win a game you don't understand the structure of. You can have great work and lose bids because you're speaking to the wrong person in the wrong language. You can underprice a job because you don't know what the agency expects your margin to look like. You can get frustrated by layers of approvals without understanding why those layers exist or who actually holds the power.

This section is the map. Before the strategy, before the treatments, before the pricing. Here's who's in the room.

THE CHAIN OF PLAYERS: BRAND, AGENCY, PRODUCTION COMPANY, CREW

The commercial production world runs on a chain. Most of the time, it looks like this:

Brand to **Agency** to **Production Company** to **Crew and Vendors**

Money flows down the chain. Creative decisions flow in both directions, but authority flows up. The brand is at the top of both flows: they write the check, and they have ultimate approval on everything that gets made. Below them, each link in the chain adds a layer of professional management, creative translation, and operational execution.

The brand is the company paying for everything. It might be a national advertiser running a broadcast campaign. It might be a mid-size tech company launching a product. It might be a regional brand that has a $150,000 budget and wants a spot that feels bigger than it costs. Whatever the scale, the brand's job is to identify a business problem, commit a budget to solve it, and approve the work that eventually goes out into the world. Brands rarely interact directly with the production company until the shoot itself. Even then, the agency is usually the buffer.

The agency is the creative intermediary. They hold the brand relationship, which in large accounts can span years or decades. They develop the campaign concept, write the scripts, and manage the approval process. When it's time to make something, the agency hires the production company. This is a critical point: in most traditional commercial work, you're not bidding to the brand. You're bidding to the agency. The agency is your client, and the brand is the agency's client.

The production company (that's you, if you're running one) takes the agency's creative brief and produces it. You provide the director. You build the budget. You hire the crew, book the locations, manage the shoot, and often oversee post-production. Your job is to execute the creative vision the agency has developed with enough craft and judgment that the result is better than what the brief imagined.

Below the production company is the crew and vendor network. The DP, the gaffer, the art department, the casting director, the location scout, the catering company, the equipment house, the VFX studio, the editorial house, the colorist, the sound mixer. Almost all of these are freelance relationships or vendor partnerships assembled per project. The production company is the connective tissue that holds all of them together.

This chain exists for a reason. The agency already has the brand relationship; they spent years building it, and the brand trusts them to manage creative execution. The production company has production infrastructure and creative talent that the agency doesn't maintain in-house. And the freelance crew model lets production companies scale up and down per project without carrying the overhead of a full-time staff.

Every link in the chain makes money from the link below it. Brands pay agencies a retainer plus a markup or commission on production. Agencies pay production companies a production budget that includes the production company's markup on costs. Production companies mark up crew and vendor costs. This is not a secret, and it's not a racket. It's how a project-based industry handles risk, expertise, and margin at every level.

WHO HOLDS THE RELATIONSHIP, AND WHO HOLDS THE POWER

Understanding the chain is the start. Understanding where the actual power lives is what lets you navigate it.

The agency holds the brand relationship. This is the single most important structural fact in commercial production. The brand chose their agency, often after a full agency review process that took months. The agency built that relationship over years of campaigns, account management, and creative development. The agency is accountable to the brand for every dollar spent and every creative decision made. That accountability is why the agency has the authority to hire (and fire) the production company.

This means the agency producer is your actual client, operationally. They sent the RFP. They manage the bid. They sign off on the budget. They give you the timeline. They're the person who calls you with questions at 7pm before a shoot. Build that relationship well and it generates consistent bid invitations. Burn it and you're off the shortlist.

But the agency producer doesn't make the creative decision alone. That's the creative director, the CD. The CD is the person whose aesthetic sensibility drives what gets selected from among the bids. When you write a treatment, you're writing it for the CD's

taste, not the agency producer's operational checklist. The best directors understand this split instinctively: speak to the producer about scope, timeline, and budget; speak to the CD about concept, tone, and feeling.

The brand client's power is real but largely exercised at approval points, not in the day-to-day. They see the treatments (sometimes), they approve the final creative direction (almost always), and they sign off on the final cut. What they don't usually do is evaluate production companies or sit in on creative calls. Their influence comes through the agency, which translates brand feedback into creative direction. Learning to read that translation layer, understanding that "the client wants it to feel more premium" means the CD needs to solve for something specific, is part of the job.

The one exception is direct-to-brand work, which we'll get to. When there's no agency in the chain, the brand's internal marketing team or Director of Content becomes the agency. The dynamic shifts significantly.

INSIDE THE AGENCY: THE ROLES THAT MATTER TO YOUR BUSINESS

Agencies are not monolithic. You'll interact with three or four distinct roles, and each one is evaluating something different.

The Creative Director has final say on creative decisions. This is the person whose taste matters most when your treatment is being read. On large accounts, the CD may be a senior figure who reviews work but isn't on every call. On smaller accounts, the CD might be the art director who wrote the brief. Know who you're writing for.

The Art Director and Copywriter are the day-to-day creative team. They develop the brief, write the script, and are often the people you talk to on the creative call. They know what the brief is trying to say better than anyone, because they wrote it. They also know what it's missing. Your job on the creative call is to draw out what they haven't put on paper yet.

The Agency Producer owns the production relationship. They manage the bid calendar, evaluate production bids, coordinate between the creative team and the production company, and handle the operational side of getting the spot made. They are the person who puts you on or off the shortlist. A great agency producer can make a difficult shoot manageable. A bad one can make a good shoot chaotic.

The Account Manager interfaces with the brand and isn't usually in the production weeds. You'll meet them on set when the client attends, and occasionally they'll relay brand feedback that affects creative direction. They're not your decision-maker, but they're the agency's brand relationship owner.

Business Affairs (BA) enters the picture at award. They handle contracts, usage licensing, talent agreements, and the legal mechanics of the production agreement. This is the person who sends you the production services agreement you'll need to review before you start pre-production.

The two roles that matter most to your day-to-day business are the agency producer and the creative director. If the CD wants you and the agency producer trusts you, you're on the shortlist. Everything else follows from that.

AGENCY WORK VS. DIRECT-TO-BRAND: TWO VERY DIFFERENT GAMES

Commercial directors who've only worked direct-to-brand are often surprised by how agency work runs. Commercial directors who've only worked with agencies are sometimes surprised by how direct work feels. They operate by different logic.

Agency work runs through the chain. The agency has developed the creative concept before you ever see the RFP. Your job is to interpret and elevate that concept, not to generate it. You're a director for hire. Your creative voice matters enormously, but it operates within a framework the agency has already built. Approvals happen in layers: production company to agency producer to creative director to account team to brand client. Every step takes time.

The upside is real: agency jobs are typically larger budgets, more defined scopes, and run through professional agency producers who know how to manage a production. A $300,000 agency job has a production infrastructure behind it. The agency producer has done this before. The timeline, while often compressed, follows known patterns. The contract is standard.

Direct-to-brand work removes the agency from the chain entirely. The brand's internal marketing team is your client. You're often helping develop the creative brief, not just interpreting it. The approval chain is shorter, usually one or two people. Decisions can come faster. You have more creative authority.

The tradeoff is that direct-to-brand clients often don't have production experience. They don't know what the AICP format is. They don't understand why 14 deliverables at five aspect ratios doubles the post-production budget. You spend more time educating the client on how production works, managing expectations around scope and timeline, and protecting your budget from scope creep. The jobs are often smaller, typically ranging from $25,000 to $150,000, though there are exceptions at well-funded tech companies and large DTC brands.

The strategic use of both types is to build a base of direct-to-brand relationships that provide reliable, lower-stress revenue while you're developing the agency relationships that unlock larger budgets. Direct-to-brand keeps the business funded. Agency work is where the ceiling is.

WHERE BOUTIQUE DIRECTOR-DRIVEN COMPANIES FIT (AND WIN)

The production company world has tiers. At the top are the large full-service shops. They have global rosters, decades of agency relationships, and handle the biggest budgets in the world. A Tier 1 shop might produce 50 to 100 commercials a year across dozens of directors. They're not a realistic competitive set for a boutique company.

In the middle are established mid-size companies with strong director rosters, consistent agency relationships, and a track record across multiple categories. This is the aspirational tier for most growing boutique companies.

At the boutique level, where most independent commercial directors are building, the company is usually director-driven. The creative reputation of the company is the reputation of one to three directors. The roster is small. The jobs are won on the strength of a specific aesthetic, a differentiated approach, or a director whose name agencies want attached to certain kinds of work.

The boutique disadvantage is real: it's harder to break onto agency rosters without a track record, and a small roster limits bandwidth for self-promotion. One director's schedule drives the whole company's availability.

The boutique advantage is less obvious but more durable. Smaller companies give individual projects more attention. The director who's pitching a $180,000 brand film at a boutique company actually cares about that job. It's not one of twenty on a production slate. The craft and creative investment per project is higher. Agencies know this, and the CDs who care about the work often prefer a boutique director who brings their whole self to a brief over a larger company where that brief would be handled by whoever's available.

The boutique director-driven model also produces closer alignment between creative and production. When the director is also the person building the budget, the treatment and the bid stay coherent. There are no translation problems between what the director imagined and what the producer thinks is achievable. That coherence shows up in the work.

Winning from a boutique position means being clear about what you do and doing it exceptionally. Not trying to be everything to every agency, but being the obvious answer for a specific type of brief.

HOW MONEY ACTUALLY FLOWS THROUGH A COMMERCIAL PRODUCTION

You need to understand how money moves through this chain: not just because you need to price correctly, but because it explains the behavior of everyone in the room.

When a brand commits a budget for a spot, that number flows through the agency first. The agency charges the brand for their services. This might be a retainer, a project fee, or a commission on production. The agency then allocates a portion of the brand's total budget to production. What reaches the production company as the stated budget has already been filtered through the agency's own economics.

The production company receives the production budget. From that budget, the production company covers all hard costs (crew, equipment, locations, casting, catering, travel, post-production) and applies a markup to those costs. The production company's markup (typically between 15 and 25 percent on direct costs) is where the company makes its margin. On a $200,000 production budget, a 20 percent markup on $150,000 in direct costs generates $30,000 in production fee. That $30,000 has to cover the director's fee (if separate from the markup), the producer's time, overhead, insurance, and company profit.

The director's fee is often negotiated separately from the production markup, particularly at the boutique level where the director's creative value is being priced independently of the operational cost of running the production. Understanding the difference between the director fee (your creative compensation), the production markup (the company's revenue on hard costs), and overhead (the cost of running the company) is foundational. Confuse any of these three and you can produce a $200,000 job and net almost nothing.

> *Jordan had been directing branded content and music videos for five years when his first real agency job came in. A regional agency, a $165,000 brand film for a regional bank, a proper RFP with an AICP-formatted bid request. He'd been doing direct-to-brand work for years and knew how to build a budget: figure out what everything costs, add a director fee on top, and submit the number.*
>
> *He listed out crew: $76,000. Post-production: $22,000. He added $16,000 for his director fee and $9,000 for his producer time coordinating the whole thing. He submitted $123,000 and felt good about leaving the agency breathing room under their stated budget. He got the award call. He ran the job well. The agency was pleased with the spots.*
>
> *When he did the final accounting, his net above direct costs was $7,800. For four weeks of prep, two shoot days, and six weeks of post. He had not filled in the markup column on the AICP bid. On $98,000 in direct costs, a 20 percent markup would have generated $19,600. He had essentially handed the job's margin back to the agency and left the exchange wondering why a good job felt like nothing.*

Crew and vendors are paid from the direct costs. The production company assembles the team, collects bids from vendors, and processes all payments. Payroll on union crew is handled through payroll companies that calculate and withhold taxes, union fringes, and benefits, typically adding 28 to 33 percent on top of the base wage.

At the end of production, the production company submits a cost report: a line-by-line accounting of actual costs versus budgeted amounts. Agencies typically hold back 10 percent of the production budget until the cost report is reviewed and approved. The holdback protects the agency (and the brand) from overpaying if the production came in under budget on any line. Getting that final 10 percent requires a clean cost report, delivered on time.

The whole system is designed to create accountability at every level. The brand is accountable to their marketing budget. The agency is accountable to the brand for cost and creative outcomes. The production company is accountable to the agency for the cost report and the work. The crew is accountable to the production company for their day rates and deliverables. Everyone has someone above them who can ask for a line-by-line accounting.

KEY TERMS YOU'LL NEED IMMEDIATELY

These are the words that signal whether you're inside the industry or outside it. Not a glossary to memorize. Just the terms that will come up in the first three months and that you want to use correctly.

Markup: The production company's percentage applied to direct costs. This is how production companies generate revenue beyond the director's fee. Not a secret, not something to hide. It's expected and known.

Work-for-hire: The contractual standard in commercial production. The brand owns everything. The production company and director retain no rights to the finished work. This is normal and not negotiable on most agency jobs.

Fringe: The cost of payroll taxes, union benefits, and workers' compensation added on top of crew wages. Typically runs 28 to 33 percent on union crew. This is a real cost that goes into your bid. It's not the markup; it's a direct cost.

Cost report: The final accounting of a production, comparing budgeted costs to actual costs. Required at wrap. The agency holds back 10 percent of the production budget until it's reviewed.

Sales rep: A person or company that represents your production company to advertising agencies. They handle relationship development and outreach in exchange for a percentage of the billings they generate, typically 10 to 15 percent of the jobs that come through their introductions.

You now have a map of the territory. The chain from brand to agency to production company to crew, how money moves through each link, who the players are and what each one is actually evaluating. This isn't theory. Every piece of it is something you'll encounter in the first real agency bid you sit across from.

Section 2 covers the bidding process from RFP to award, including the parts nobody puts in writing.

SECTION TWO

The Invisible Tournament

How Commercial Bidding Actually Works

> *The client names, company names, and identifying details in this book have been changed to protect confidentiality. The situations, numbers, and outcomes are real.*

In March 2026, we pitched a $300,000 job to a software infrastructure company. The creative call went long in the best way. We came back with a concept anchored in craft film technique: documentary-style, real engineers, real problems, the kind of work that makes technical products feel human. We put genuine thought into it. The deck was specific. The approach was differentiated.

The client sat through our presentation and said: "I was laughing, I was crying."

Their solutions engineer said: "I did not see this pitch going this way."

We didn't get the job.

The software client chose a competitor. The marketer left the door open for future work, and I believe he meant it. But we were not awarded that job. And as I sat with that result afterward, I kept coming back to the same thing: we did everything right. We understood the brief. We brought a point of view. We made them feel something in the room. And we lost.

If that unsettles you, good. It should. Because what I just described is not a failure story. It's the most honest description I can give you of commercial bidding. You are going to enter tournaments where you don't know all the rules, where you don't know who else is competing, and where doing excellent work is necessary but not sufficient to win. The faster you understand that, the more useful this section becomes.

HOW A JOB IS BORN: FROM BRAND BRIEF TO DIRECTOR SEARCH

Every commercial job starts as a problem a brand needs to solve. A product launching in Q3. A brand perception issue surfaced in last year's customer research. An annual campaign that needs refreshing. A new market they're entering. The creative execution comes later. First, someone inside the company has decided that video is the answer, and they've secured a budget to prove it.

That budget number matters more than most directors realize. In most commercial work, the brand doesn't come to you directly. They go to their agency. The agency, which already holds the account and has existing creative authority, takes the brand's business problem and translates it into a campaign brief. That brief becomes the script, or the treatment brief, or the creative direction document that eventually lands in your hands.

The agency producer is not posting a job listing. They're not running an open call. They're pulling from a mental list: a shortlist of production companies they've worked with before, heard good things about, or been introduced to by a sales rep they trust. They send out 2, 3, maybe 4 RFPs. Sometimes they invite 5 companies if the budget is large enough and the brand requires it. If you're not on the list, you don't know the job exists. That's the first thing to understand about the commercial bidding world: there is no public market for these jobs. The market is made of relationships, shortlists, and introductions.

THE RFP: WHAT IT IS, WHAT IT MEANS, AND WHY YOU WERE (OR WEREN'T) INVITED

The Request for Proposal arrives as an email from the agency producer: script or treatment brief, production parameters, timeline, and sometimes a budget range. Sometimes not. Three things matter.

The budget number. If the RFP includes a number, it's real. It has cleared at least two layers of brand-side approval. Some agencies shade it 10 to 15 percent below their actual ceiling, but the number in the document is a ceiling, not a starting position. If there's no budget in the RFP, submit anyway. Sometimes the brand hasn't locked a number yet and the bids help them figure out what this should cost.

Why you were invited. One of three reasons: the agency producer knows your work and it fits the brief category, your sales rep made a relevant introduction, or the creative director specifically requested you. In commercial production, a $400,000 car job invitation is a signal about how you're categorized. Pay attention to the type of jobs you're getting called for. They tell you what box you live in.

Why you weren't invited. Three reasons: the creative team doesn't know you exist, the agency producer has had a bad experience with your company (or heard about one), or your reel doesn't match the brief. The first and third are solvable with time. The second requires a direct conversation.

THE CREATIVE CALL: HOW TO LISTEN LIKE A DIRECTOR WHO'S GOING TO WIN

After you receive the RFP, you'll be offered a creative call with the agency team, usually the agency producer plus one or both of the creative team. This call happens before you write your treatment, which is exactly when it should happen.

Most directors use the creative call to pitch. That's a mistake.

The creative call is not a pitch opportunity. It is a research opportunity. The agency has spent weeks with this brief. They know things about the brand, the campaign context, the internal political constraints, and the creative direction that are not in the document they sent you. Your job on this call is to draw that out.

Ask questions that reveal the emotional target, not the technical requirements. "What's the one thing you want someone to feel 30 seconds after watching this?" is more useful than "How many shoot days are you budgeting for?" You can calculate shoot days from the parameters. You cannot calculate the emotional brief from a script.

Ask about what they've already tried. "Has the brand done anything like this before? What worked, what didn't?" The answer tells you what the agency is trying to move away from. Moving toward is always easier to describe when you understand what came before.

Ask about approvals. "Who has creative sign-off on the final spot? Is it primarily you, or does the brand client get a strong vote?" The answer changes your treatment strategy significantly. A CD who has creative authority and wants to take a risk will respond to a more directorial treatment. A job where the client has final approval over every frame requires a treatment that the client can follow and approve, which is a different document.

Take notes. Not mental notes. Written notes, or a recording if you ask permission. The specific language the creative team uses to describe the feeling they want, phrases like "we keep saying 'quiet confidence'" or "the brand wants to feel more like Patagonia and less like Nike," belongs in your treatment. When the agency reads a phrase they used in the creative call reflected back at them in your treatment, it does something psychological: it tells them you actually listened.

> *Dana had been trying to get in the door at one particular agency for two years. When the creative call finally came on a regional automotive brief, she was ready. She had references pulled. She had ideas. She walked into the call prepared to make an impression.*
>
> *The creative team spent the first ten minutes explaining where the brand was trying to go. Dana spent the next twenty explaining what she could bring to it. She pitched her visual approach, described locations she had in mind, talked about her category experience. The agency awarded to a director who had asked three questions on the creative call: what the brand was moving away from, who had final creative approval, and what one feeling they wanted the viewer to carry out. Then she'd listened for the answers.*
>
> *Dana's treatment was longer. It was thorough. The other director's treatment opened with the exact phrase the CD had used on the creative call to describe what they were reaching for. Dana thought she'd lost on category experience. She hadn't. She'd lost the call before she'd written a word.*

THE TREATMENT AND THE BID: TWO DOCUMENTS, ONE DECISION

You will submit two things: a treatment and a bid. The agency will tell you the treatment and bid are evaluated separately, and that's partially true. In practice, they're one decision. A great treatment with an impossible bid gets passed over. A competitive bid with a weak treatment gets passed over faster.

The treatment is your entry into the creative conversation, and the bid is your evidence that you can manage the job responsibly. They're evaluated by different people at the agency (creative team vs. producer), but they combine into a single impression of your company.

On the bid side: the number you submit is not just a number. It's a signal about your judgment. Underbid a $300,000 job at $180,000 and the agency producer knows you don't understand the scope, which means they have to worry about surprises on set, cost overruns, and that awkward conversation at wrap when you're asking for a change order because you underbid the post production. Overbid at $420,000 and you're out of the conversation before the treatment gets read.

The bid is a precision instrument. Every line item is a decision. A well-constructed bid communicates competence in the same way a well-constructed treatment communicates creative vision. Both matter.

HOW AWARDS ACTUALLY HAPPEN (AND WHY THE "BEST" TREATMENT DOESN'T ALWAYS WIN)

The agency producer reads every bid. The creative team reads every treatment. They typically do this independently, then come together in an internal discussion. What happens in that discussion is where the tournament becomes genuinely invisible.

Here's what gets weighed in an award decision that the RFP document will never tell you:

Existing relationship. If one of the other production companies in the bid has an established relationship with this agency, with years of good jobs, no surprises, and a producer who is already trusted, that history is worth something in the room. Not enough to overcome a dramatically better creative pitch, but enough to tip a close decision.

Budget reality. If two treatments are genuinely excellent and one bid is $30,000 lower, budget wins. Agencies are not oblivious to money. Brands approve specific amounts, and agency producers get evaluated on how well they manage to budget. A creative decision that saves the brand $30,000 is a producer win.

Director fit. Sometimes the brief is right for your company's aesthetic but the creative director has a specific director in mind: someone whose work they've been watching, whose name they've been waiting for a reason to hire. You might submit the best treatment in the bid and lose because the CD had already decided this job was the one.

Procurement. On large brand accounts, procurement teams require triple bids specifically to audit the decision. In those cases, the award is often made before the bid opens. The preferred production company is known, and the two other companies in the bid are invited to legitimize the process. This is more common at larger agencies with bigger brand accounts.

The chemistry call. Some agencies schedule a final presentation call before award. The shortlisted company comes back in to present their treatment in person or on video. This is where a different kind of evaluation happens: can we spend 20 days with this director and not lose our minds? Does this person listen? Are they going to be a problem on set?

> *Ryan spent nine days on a treatment for a $450,000 automotive campaign. He had been trying to break into this particular agency for two years. The creative call had felt a little flat, the agency team asked mostly surface questions and got off the call twelve minutes early, but Ryan told himself they were busy. He put everything into the deck.*
>
> *He didn't get the job. Three weeks later, through an EP in his market, he found out the job had gone to a production company with equity ties to the agency's holding company. The recommendation had been made before the RFP went out. Ryan had been invited to fulfill a procurement checkbox.*
>
> *What Ryan learned, slowly, was how to read the signals before he put in nine days. A short pitch window. A disengaged creative call. An agency team that asks no follow-up questions on specific line items. These don't guarantee a check bid situation. But they're worth knowing before you decide how much of yourself to put into the treatment.*

THE UNSPOKEN RULES: WHAT EVERY EXPERIENCED EP KNOWS AND NOBODY SAYS OUT LOUD

The triple bid is often not a real competition. When procurement requires three bids, agencies frequently have a preferred production company before the RFP goes out. The other two bids satisfy compliance requirements. Being in a procurement bid means your treatment is on the CD's desk, and that's worth something. But calibrate your expectations.

Budget ranges are negotiating positions. When an agency says $200,000 is the number, most of the time that's the real number. But sometimes there's flexibility, particularly on jobs where the brand genuinely wants a specific director or production company and the budget was set before the scope was fully understood. If your bid comes in higher than the RFP budget and your treatment is the strongest in the bid, ask.

Responding late loses bids. The bid deadline is not a suggestion. An agency producer who sends out an RFP to four production companies and gets three responses on deadline and one response two days late is going to award to one of the three. Being late tells them you don't understand how agency timelines work, or that you don't prioritize their job. Both are disqualifying signals.

The treatment is read in 7 minutes. The creative team is looking at your treatment in between a brand presentation, a client call, and three other open projects. If the concept isn't clear by page 3, you've lost the reader. Design your treatment for someone reading fast.

Agencies talk to each other. This is a small industry. Agency producers who have good experiences with production companies tell other agency producers. Agency producers who have bad experiences tell other agency producers too. Your reputation as an operator travels through this network faster than your reel does.

The award call is not the contract. When an agency producer calls to tell you you've been awarded the job, that is the beginning of a new negotiation, not the end of one. The bid may need to be revised. The scope may have changed. "We'd like to award to you, but

can you work with $185,000 instead of your $210,000 bid?" is a common opening to the post-award conversation. Have a clear sense of where your floor is before you get on that call.

Ghosting after a loss is a mistake. If you've bid a job and lost it, send a short, professional note to the agency producer. Thank them for the invitation. Tell them you'd welcome the chance to work together on a future project. This takes three minutes and it is remembered.

AFTER THE AWARD: WHAT THE PRODUCTION COMPANY'S FIRST 48 HOURS LOOK LIKE

You got the call. You're awarded. In the first 48 hours, three things need to happen simultaneously.

First: a cost confirmation conversation with the agency producer. If the agency came back with a revised number at award, you need to align in writing on what is and isn't included at the adjusted budget before you start pre-production. A phone call confirming a budget revision is not enough. Get it in an email.

Second: a creative alignment call with the CD and/or creative team. Your treatment won, which means the agency believes in your concept. But between submission and award, sometimes the client has had opinions about the treatment, the scope has been adjusted, or the timing has changed. Before you book a single location scout, confirm that the creative direction you pitched is still the creative direction the agency wants to execute.

Third: start calendaring. The shoot date in the RFP was an estimate. Now it becomes a target. You need to know immediately whether that target is achievable and what the pre-production timeline looks like. Pre-production on a properly scoped commercial takes 3 to 6 weeks at minimum: 4 weeks for a clean, simple project; 6 to 8 weeks for anything with complex casting, custom sets, or locations that need permitting.

THE FULL ARC: A ONE-PAGE MAP

Every commercial job moves through these stages. Your role and your leverage shift at each one.

Brief. The brand's problem turns into a campaign. You're not here yet.

RFP. The agency invites 2 to 5 production companies to bid. You get the call if you're on their list.

Creative call. You ask the questions nobody else is asking. You listen for what the brief was trying to say.

Treatment + bid. You submit your creative vision and your cost structure simultaneously. Both documents represent your company.

Internal evaluation. The agency reads your work against 2 to 4 other submissions. Creative, budget, relationship history, fit: all weighed.

Award. One company gets the call. The others get silence, or a polite decline, or nothing.

Pre-production. 3 to 6 weeks of building the job from the ground up.

Production. The shoot. Usually 1 to 5 days. Your creative is executed.

Post-production. 4 to 10 weeks of editorial, color, sound, finishing. The agency and brand have approval at every stage.

Delivery. Assets delivered. The spot runs. If it works, the brand and agency talk about the next one.

You are going to spend a meaningful portion of your career building bids that don't win. Some of those losses will make sense: a stronger treatment, a better price, a relationship you don't have yet. Some of them won't make sense, and never fully will. You can do everything right and lose. That happened to us: a $300,000 job we pitched and lost despite a genuine emotional response from the room.

What you can control is whether you understood the tournament well enough to compete intentionally. Whether the treatment you submitted showed that you heard the brief. Whether the bid you submitted showed you understand the scope. Whether, when the loss comes, you handled it in a way that kept the door open.

Section 3 covers treatment writing in full: what agencies are actually reading for, how to make them feel seen, and the specific structural choices that separate a winning treatment from a good one that didn't win.

SECTION THREE

Make Them Feel It

Treatment Writing That Wins

> *The client names, company names, and identifying details in this book have been changed to protect confidentiality. The situations, numbers, and outcomes are real.*

Most directors write treatments that describe what they're going to do. The ones that win describe what the spot has always been trying to become.

That distinction sounds like the kind of thing someone says at a directing workshop. It isn't. It is the actual difference between a treatment the creative team reads once and files, and a treatment the CD prints out, marks up, and brings into the internal meeting to argue for.

WHAT A TREATMENT ACTUALLY IS (AND WHAT AGENCIES ARE REALLY READING FOR)

A treatment is a director's written and visual response to a creative brief. It presents the director's interpretation of the script or concept, describes the tone and visual world they intend to build, and gives the agency enough specificity to believe the vision is real and achievable.

That's what a treatment is. Here's what it's actually for.

A treatment is an audition. Not for the job exactly, but for the answer to a specific question the agency is asking: does this director understand what we're trying to make? The agency creative team has spent weeks or months with this brief. They have a feeling in mind, a tone they can almost hear, an image they keep seeing when they close their eyes and think about the spot. When an agency reads your treatment, they are checking

whether you heard them. Not whether you have impressive ideas. Not whether you have technical credentials. Not whether your reel covers the category. All of that matters in the aggregate, but the treatment is specifically an evaluation of whether your version of this spot is the version they've been trying to make.

There is a second question layered underneath the first: can we trust this director to execute? The agency producer reads the treatment differently than the CD does. The producer is looking for evidence that you understand the scope, that your approach is achievable within the budget, and that you're the kind of director who will be a professional to work with. The treatment has to convince the creative team and the producer simultaneously, which means it has to hold together both creatively and operationally.

THE ANATOMY OF A WINNING TREATMENT

A winning treatment isn't a matter of length or format. It's a matter of hierarchy. The elements you lead with and the order you develop them in are the actual choices that determine whether the agency feels understood.

Here's the hierarchy that works: **Concept first, Tone second, Execution third.**

Concept: What is this spot really about? Not the script's surface content, but the human truth underneath it. A spot about a car is never really about the car. It's about freedom, or competence, or aspiration, or the relationship between a parent and a child, or the specific pleasure of being somewhere your phone can't follow you. The brief will tell you what the script contains. The concept section of your treatment should tell the agency what the spot means.

Directors who lead with concept signal that they've understood the brief at the right level. Directors who skip concept and go straight to execution signal that they've read the script, not the brief. The script is the text. The brief is what the client is trying to accomplish. The best treatments are written in response to the brief, not the script.

Tone: Once the concept is established, tone describes how the spot should feel. Not a visual description. Tone is emotional. "Documentary-style, real humans, quiet dignity" is a tone description. "Sony Venice, anamorphic, desaturated palette" is a technical description. The first one tells the agency whether the spot will resonate emotionally with their client's audience. The second one tells the agency what camera you want to rent.

Tone is what the CD carries out of the treatment read. When they're in the internal meeting arguing for your approach over two other treatments, they're not arguing about the camera. They're arguing about the feeling. Give them something to hold.

Execution: Once the first two sections have established the emotional foundation, execution earns the right to be detailed. Here's where the visual references live, the casting direction, the location approach, the specific scene interpretations. Here's where you can show technical fluency and directorial specificity. But execution is the third act, not the first. It pays off a setup the first two sections have built.

Most losing treatments have the order inverted. They lead with mood boards and camera references, bury the concept in a paragraph late in the document, and end with a vague statement about the emotional intent. The creative team reads them and thinks: technically capable, doesn't understand what we're making.

MAKING THE AGENCY FEEL SEEN: HOW TO RESPOND TO THE BRIEF, NOT JUST EXECUTE IT

The most important thing a treatment can do is make the creative team feel understood.

The art director and copywriter wrote the brief. They have been living with this brief, revising this brief, arguing with their CD about this brief, presenting this brief to the client and then revising it again. By the time it lands in your inbox, that brief carries weeks of professional energy, creative debate, and internal compromise.

When you respond to that brief with a treatment that simply executes the script, you're saying: I received your document. When you respond with a treatment that articulates something the creative team felt but couldn't quite say, you're saying: I heard you.

The technique for achieving this is deceptively simple, and it comes from the creative call. On the creative call, the art director and copywriter will say things they didn't put in the brief. They'll describe an emotion they keep coming back to. They'll say a phrase that isn't in the brief document, a phrase that crystallizes what they want. Write it down. That phrase belongs in the opening of your treatment.

When the creative team opens your treatment and finds the specific language they used in the creative call, reflected back at them as the conceptual foundation of your approach, something happens. It isn't just recognition. It's relief. Out of the two, three, or four treatments they're going to read, yours is the one that confirms their idea had merit.

> *Marcus had been directing corporate and healthcare content for six years when he got his first invitation to bid a proper agency campaign. The treatment was 22 pages. It covered casting direction for four talent types, location mood boards across three cities, a full scene-by-scene breakdown, and a technical approach section that demonstrated his command of frame rates, lenses, and color pipeline. Every element of the brief was accounted for. He submitted it two days early.*
>
> *The job went to a director with half his credits and a treatment that was nine pages long. The other director's treatment opened with a paragraph that started: "I keep coming back to what you said on the call: that this brand wants to feel like the friend who actually knows what they're talking about. Not the advisor in the suit. The person you trust because they've been through it themselves." That sentence was almost verbatim language the art director had used in the creative call.*
>
> *Marcus had heard that language on the call too. He had moved past it and gotten to the execution. The other director had stopped there and treated it as the foundation.*

VISUAL REFERENCES DONE RIGHT: MOOD BOARDS, COMPARISONS, AND WHAT NOT TO STEAL

Every treatment includes visual references. Most treatments include them badly.

Visual references in a treatment do two jobs. They communicate aesthetic direction (here is the visual world I'm building) and they communicate taste (here is how I see the world, what I'm drawn to, what I think is beautiful or interesting or true). Agencies read both, but most directors understand only the first.

The principle behind a strong visual reference section is curation, not coverage. You are not trying to show the agency every visual note in the spot. You are trying to show them the core aesthetic logic: three to five images that, together, define the visual world completely enough that anyone looking at them can feel the spot before it's made.

Don't steal from competitive spots. If you're bidding a car brief and your reference section is full of images from other car commercials, you're showing the agency what everyone in the category is already doing. References from outside the category signal that your aesthetic thinking is broader than the brief and that your visual world will be distinct.

Don't over-reference contemporary work. If every image in your treatment was shot in the last 18 months by someone whose Instagram the CD is already following, your treatment lacks a perspective. Historical photography, film stills, architectural photography, painting: these show a director who has been building a visual vocabulary over time.

Be specific about why. For each reference, one sentence. "This is the quality of light in every exterior scene" is more useful than "Mood/atmosphere." The distinction matters because it tells the agency you're in control of your own references and not just building a collage.

THE DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT: WHY IT MATTERS MORE THAN YOU THINK

The director's statement is typically a half-page to one page positioned near the opening of the treatment, after the concept section. Most directors treat it as a formal obligation. Most director's statements are entirely forgettable.

A great director's statement does something specific. It reveals the director's point of view, not on this particular spot, but on the underlying human truth the spot is trying to touch.

A weak director's statement: "This brief speaks to me because I've always been drawn to authentic storytelling. I believe this campaign can connect with audiences in a genuine way."

That statement could appear in any treatment, for any brief, from any director. It says nothing.

A strong director's statement: "I keep coming back to a specific memory: watching my father watch my daughter. Three generations in a room, and he's quiet, just watching her. That quality of attention is what I want this spot to feel like. Not performance. Not a constructed family. Just the actual texture of being seen by someone who loves you."

That statement could only be written by a person who has had that thought. It is specific, personal, and it connects directly to what the brief is about. When the CD reads it, they learn something about who wrote it. The director's statement is your one opportunity in the treatment to introduce yourself as a human being rather than a service provider.

COMMON TREATMENT MISTAKES THAT LOSE BIDS

Opening with execution. The treatment opens with camera specs, location lookbook images, or casting notes before establishing any concept. First impressions in a treatment are extremely difficult to recover from.

Restating the brief. The concept section of the treatment is a summary of the script. The agency wrote that script. They don't need you to describe it to them. Your concept section should say something about the brief that the brief itself didn't say.

Too many references. A mood board of 25 images is not a strong vision. It is indecision made visual. Cut ruthlessly.

The generic enthusiasm paragraph. "I'm incredibly excited about this brief and I believe we can make something truly special together." This language is in approximately 60 percent of all treatments submitted. It means nothing. Cut it.

Underselling the emotional territory. A technically accomplished treatment that describes execution in precise detail but never says what the spot should feel like is a production estimate, not a creative vision.

The shot list. Including a scene-by-scene or shot-by-shot breakdown shifts the document from a vision presentation to a technical plan. Agencies are not ready to approve a shot list when they're evaluating bids.

Too long. A treatment should be as long as it needs to be and not a word longer. For most 30-second to 60-second spots, this is 8 to 14 pages including visual references. A 30-page treatment is not more impressive than a 12-page one. It is more intimidating and harder to evaluate quickly.

WHEN YOU DON'T LOVE THE BRIEF: HOW TO BRING YOURSELF TO SOMETHING YOU DIDN'T INITIATE

You will be invited to bid on briefs that don't excite you. There are three honest approaches to this situation. The mistake is pretending a fourth option exists, where you write a treatment that you don't believe in and hope the agency doesn't notice.

Find the human truth underneath the client's language. Most briefs are written in marketing language, and marketing language is inherently removed from human experience. "Empowering consumers to take control of their financial futures" is marketing language. Underneath it is a story about anxiety, and the specific relief of not feeling behind anymore.

Reframe the brief. If your read of the brief tells you that the agency has gotten the territory slightly wrong, you can propose it. "I'm going to give you the brief as written, and I'm also going to show you a version of this that I think is truer to what the brand actually wants to say." This requires a light touch and a strong concept, but it can win jobs.

Decline gracefully. You are not obligated to bid every job you're invited to. If the brief is so far outside your creative territory that any treatment you write will be false, declining is the professional choice. Call the agency producer, thank them for the invitation, be specific about why this brief isn't the right fit, and express genuine interest in the next invitation. Declining a job you can't do well is better relationship management than submitting a treatment you can't stand behind.

> *A director I'll call Daniel got an invitation to bid from a mid-size agency he'd been trying to get in front of for almost a year. The brief was an automotive lifestyle campaign: a truck brand, open roads, a certain kind of freedom narrative. Daniel sat with it for two days before he called back. His work was human-scale and intimate, built around small truths between people. He called the agency producer and told her directly that he didn't think he was the right director for this brief.*
>
> *Six months later, she called again. A technology services company was launching a campaign built around their field engineers, real people solving infrastructure problems. It was exactly Daniel's territory. He built a treatment that opened with the specific language the agency producer had used on the creative call. At the award call, she mentioned the automotive brief unprompted. "You told me the truth," she said. "A lot of people just submit something." The job became his first $400K agency engagement.*

TREATMENT LENGTH, FORMAT, AND PRESENTATION: THE PRACTICAL DETAILS

Format. Treatments are typically presented as PDF documents. If the RFP specifies a format, use it. If it doesn't, a clean PDF with a considered layout is standard.

Length. 8 to 14 pages for most 30-60 second spots. Longer for multi-spot campaigns, brand films, or complex projects with multiple locations and extensive casting.

Casting direction. Include this. "Real people, non-actors, 35-50, ethnically diverse, working class, weathered but not broken" tells the agency something specific. "Authentic talent" tells them nothing.

Delivery. Submit on time. This is not flexible. Being the director who misses the bid deadline is an identity you do not want to carry into agency relationships.

File size. Keep the PDF under 25MB. Large-file treatments are a friction point for every person the agency producer needs to forward it to. If your visual references require high-res images, compress them to screen resolution.

THE JOB BEFORE THE JOB

The treatment is the job before the job. Before you're on set, before you're in pre-production, before you're even awarded, you're directing. You're making choices about what this spot is about and what it should feel like. You're editing. You're casting in language. You're building the visual world from available references.

Directors who understand this write treatments that read like the first act of the production, because they are. The creative team should feel, reading your treatment, that the spot already exists somewhere and you're describing it back to them.

That feeling doesn't come from being comprehensive. It comes from having thought about the brief at the right level, which is the level of human experience underneath the marketing language, and then describing what you found there with specificity and conviction.

Section 4 covers the full pricing framework: director fees, production markup, overhead math, and how to hold your number when an agency pushes back.

SECTION FOUR

Name Your Price

The Pricing Framework

> *The client names, company names, and identifying details in this book have been changed to protect confidentiality. The situations, numbers, and outcomes are real.*

Most directors underprice themselves once, overprice themselves once, and then spend the next five years not knowing which mistake they're making.

The problem isn't greed or insecurity. It's that nobody explains the structure. Your director fee is not the same as your markup, and your markup is not the same as your profit. Confuse those three things and you can win a $150,000 job, deliver the work on time and on budget, and walk away with $11,000 wondering what happened.

WHY COMMERCIAL DIRECTORS CHRONICALLY UNDERCHARGE

The undercharging problem is structural. It's not a confidence failure.

When you're starting out, you have no price history. You don't know what the market pays for a director with your reel at your level on a job of this size. Nobody tells you. There's no published rate card for commercial directors the way there's a union scale for camera operators. You make something up based on what you made last time, or what a friend told you they charged, or what feels like enough to justify the work.

That number is almost always low.

It's low because you're not accounting for the cost of the company you're running. It's low because you're not separating your personal income from the company's revenue. And it's low because the clients who find you early tend to be clients with smaller budgets, and you calibrate to what they can spend.

Once you've set a number, it anchors everything that comes after. The client who paid $18,000 for a brand video refers you to their colleague, who expects a similar number. You're building a pricing floor from the lowest jobs instead of the highest. Two years in, you have a track record of $15,000 to $25,000 direct-to-brand jobs and you can't figure out why nobody's paying you $75,000. The fix is not confidence. The fix is math.

THE PRICING STACK

There are three separate things inside a commercial production budget. Understanding them distinctly changes how you build your numbers.

The director's fee is your creative compensation. It's what you're paid for the creative work: developing the concept, collaborating on the treatment, directing the shoot. On a small direct-to-brand job, this might be $2,500. On an agency job with a real production budget, it might be $8,000 to $25,000. At the high end of commercial work, a director fee on a national broadcast campaign can be $75,000 to $150,000.

The production markup is the production company's percentage applied to below-the-line costs: crew, equipment, locations, casting, catering, travel, and post-production. The standard range in commercial production is 15 to 25 percent. This is not padding. This is the company's revenue on the operational work of producing the job. On a $150,000 production with $120,000 in direct costs, a 20 percent markup generates $24,000. That $24,000 has to cover the company's operating costs: insurance, payroll overhead, accounting, software, producer time that isn't line-itemed, and company profit.

Overhead is what it costs to run the company whether you have a job or not. Liability insurance. E&O insurance. Payroll company fees. Accounting. Software. The producer you've started part-timing. The rep you're paying a monthly retainer or percentage to. This is the number most boutique producers don't calculate until they've been running a company for three years and they're wondering why every good month leads to a flat bank account.

Director fee, production markup, overhead. Three separate things. They interact, but they are not the same thing. When you confuse them, you produce jobs that look successful on paper and feel wrong in practice.

THE MINIMUM VIABLE RATE

Before you walk into any bid, you need to know one number: the floor. The MVR, the Minimum Viable Rate, is the lowest price you can accept on a given job and still keep the company alive.

Step 1: Know your monthly overhead.

- Business insurance (general liability plus E&O): $400 to $800 per month
- Accounting and bookkeeping: $300 to $500 per month
- Payroll service fees: $75 to $150 per month
- Software (editing suite, project management, cloud storage): $150 to $300 per month
- Phone and communication: $100 to $200 per month
- Sales rep costs (retainer or percentage allocation): $500 to $1,500 per month
- Miscellaneous (contracts, legal review, trade subscriptions): $200 to $400 per month

For a lean boutique company, monthly overhead runs $1,500 to $3,500. For a company with a dedicated producer on staff and a physical office, it's $5,000 to $10,000 per month before anyone works on a single job. Call it $2,500 as a realistic baseline for a one to two person boutique operation.

Step 2: Know your desired take-home. This is the personal income you need from the company to pay your actual bills. Be honest. Don't inflate it and don't minimize it. If you need $5,000 a month to live, add your $2,500 in overhead. You need to generate $7,500 a month to break even.

Step 3: Know your billable days. How many days in a month can you realistically bill? A realistic figure for a working independent is 8 to 12 billable days per month. At 10 billable days and $7,500 in monthly needs, your MVR is $750 per day before any company profit. Below that number, you're losing ground.

A $15,000 direct-to-brand job that takes 20 days of actual work, prep through revisions, nets you $750 per day before the company's markup. After overhead, your personal draw is near zero. The job looks like money. The company is standing still. This is what chronic underpricing looks like from the inside.

MARKUP MATH: WHAT IT ACTUALLY COVERS

The production markup is the mechanism by which commercial production companies make money on the operational work of producing jobs. It is standard, known by every agency producer, and not something to apologize for or obscure.

You take every direct production cost and apply a percentage. On a $100,000 direct cost total, a 20 percent markup generates $20,000. That $20,000 appears in the "production fee" line on your AICP budget. The markup is not hidden. Agency producers read AICP budgets line by line. They see the markup. They know what it is.

Standard commercial markup by budget tier:

Direct-to-brand, smaller budgets: 20 to 25 percent. The higher end is justified because these clients require more management, have less production infrastructure, and generate more scope variance.

Agency work, mid-size budgets ($75K to $300K): 15 to 20 percent. The agency expects a professional rate. They've seen the markup on hundreds of bids. 20 percent is normal.

Large-budget agency work ($300K and up): 12 to 18 percent. At scale, the direct costs are large enough that even a 15 percent markup generates real revenue.

What the markup actually covers: producer time that isn't line-itemed; insurance overages; the cost of errors (equipment damaged on set, a vendor who invoices differently than quoted, a weather delay); and company profit after overhead.

When a client pushes back on your markup, the answer is not to apologize. "This is the standard for commercial production at this budget level, and it covers the operational infrastructure that makes this job executable." That is the complete sentence.

OVERHEAD MATH: THE REAL COST OF RUNNING THE COMPANY

Most boutique production companies don't do this math until year three. Here is the real picture.

Realistic monthly overhead for a growing boutique:

- Business insurance (GL plus E&O): $600 per month
- Workers' comp and payroll infrastructure: $300 per month
- Accounting and bookkeeping: $500 per month
- Legal (contracts, periodic retainer): $300 per month
- Software (Adobe CC, Frame.io, production management): $250 per month
- Sales rep costs: $800 per month
- Marketing (reel updates, website, materials): $200 per month
- Professional development and industry: $150 per month
- Contingency: $300 per month

Total: approximately $3,400 per month. Annualized: $40,800 a year before you pay yourself, before you work on a single job.

A company doing $400,000 a year in total production revenue with a 20 percent markup on $300,000 in direct costs generates $60,000 in production fees. Against $40,800 in overhead and a $60,000 target personal draw, you're at break-even. Every year. No matter how good the revenue number looks. The path out is pricing correctly so the markup on each job actually covers that month's overhead allocation plus margin.

THE $300,000 JOB: WHAT THAT BUDGET ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

Here is roughly how a $300,000 production breaks down for a multi-asset brand campaign: a hero film, cutdowns, and testimonial pieces with two shoot days plus second unit, multiple locations.

- Above the line (director fee, EP, line producer, creative development): $45,000 to $55,000
- Crew below the line (DP, gaffer, grip, sound, PA, HMU, wardrobe): $55,000 to $65,000
- Equipment (cameras, lenses, lighting, grip package, production vehicles): $40,000 to $50,000
- Locations (permits, fees, set build if applicable): $15,000 to $25,000
- Casting and talent: $20,000 to $30,000
- Art department and wardrobe: $10,000 to $20,000
- Catering, transport, and production support: $15,000 to $20,000
- Post-production (edit, color, sound, VFX, deliverables): $45,000 to $65,000
- Production markup (15 to 20 percent on direct costs): $38,000 to $50,000
- Contingency (5 to 10 percent): $15,000 to $25,000

When you submit a $300,000 bid, you can defend every number. The confidence to hold $300,000 doesn't come from bravado. It comes from knowing you've done the math and the math is right.

THE CREW-ONLY BID: HOW LEAN JOBS CHANGE THE MATH

Not every bid includes everything. Some jobs come in where the client already has a director, already has equipment, and needs a production company to do one specific thing: put the right crew together and manage the execution.

When you're supplying crew only, your markup base is smaller. You might be marking up $28,000 in crew wages and $5,000 in support costs. At 20 percent on $33,000, your production fee is $6,600. The math on a lean single-day production might look like this:

- DP, 1 day: $2,200
- Camera operator, 1 day: $1,500
- Gaffer, 1 day: $1,400
- Key grip, 1 day: $1,200
- Sound mixer, 1 day: $1,200
- 2 PAs, 1 day each: $900
- Hair and makeup, 1 day: $900
- Fringes on wages (28 percent): $2,884
- Support costs (logistics, comms, production supplies): $3,000
- Producer and coordinator time: $4,800
- Markup at 20 percent on direct costs: $3,037

That builds a lean single-day production around $23,000. The lesson is not about the specific numbers. It's about understanding what kind of job you're bidding before you open the budget template.

HOLDING YOUR NUMBER

The push is coming. It always comes.

You submit a bid. The agency comes back: "We have another bid that came in at $X, which is $30,000 less than yours. Can you get there?"

Here is what you don't do. You don't immediately agree and start finding line items to cut. And you don't get defensive and explain how hard you worked on the budget.

Here is what you do: ask what changed. "To get to that number, we'd need to adjust the scope. Which elements are flexible?" Then go through the budget with them. Are they willing to reduce shoot days? Cut a support crew position? Reduce post-production deliverables? Every cut has a consequence. Make sure the client understands the consequence before they agree to the cut.

> *Teresa had been producing branded content for eight years when a regional healthcare network came to her with a five-video content series. She quoted $214,000. The client came back: "We have another production company who can do this for $168,000. Can you get there?" Instead of negotiating immediately, she asked for thirty minutes on the phone. She walked the client through the budget line by line, explained what the $168,000 number either was missing or compromising, and showed them what five videos that underperformed would cost in reshoots and timeline.*
>
> *She did not get the job at $214,000. The client went with the lower bid. Six weeks later, the client called her back. The lower-bid company had run over budget by $22,000 on just the first location day. They needed someone to take over the remaining two shoots. Teresa quoted them $94,000 for two videos, which they accepted, and finished the series at a higher effective rate than her original bid would have delivered.*

Walking away from jobs that are below your floor is not a negotiating tactic. It's math. A job that loses you money every day you're working on it is not a job. It's a drain. The production company that survives is the one that knows the difference.

THE UNDERPRICING TRAP

Here is what doesn't get said clearly enough about underpricing: it's not just a revenue problem. It's a client selection problem.

When you price low, you attract clients who selected you because of price. Those clients make every future decision based on price. When you try to raise your rates later, they don't come with you. And while you were building a client base that won't pay more, you were unavailable to the clients who would have.

Strategic underpricing has a shelf life. It makes sense for 12 to 18 months when you're building. After that, you need to be raising rates consistently. A 10 to 15 percent rate increase annually on direct-to-brand work is normal and expected. If your clients resist every increase, you have the wrong clients.

The math on the underpricing trap is brutal over time. Say you're doing 12 direct-to-brand jobs a year at an average of $18,000 each. That's $216,000 in revenue. Against $40,800 in overhead and a $72,000 personal draw target, you're running at a significant deficit before you count taxes or any savings.

Raise that average job to $30,000 through better pricing and better client selection. Same 12 jobs. $360,000 in revenue. Against the same overhead and same personal draw, suddenly the company has room.

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF PRICE ANCHORING IN BIDS

Pricing is not just math. It's communication. The first number you say in a conversation becomes the anchor. Every number after it is measured against that first number. If you say $75,000 and then propose $50,000 as a scope-reduced option, they experience the $50,000 as a deal. Same number. Different anchor.

Present your full-scope bid first. This is not an inflated number. It's the real cost of doing the job the right way. Then, if the client needs to adjust, you come down from that number with specific scope reductions attached. The reduced number lands against the full-scope anchor.

Price communicates quality, not just cost. A bid that comes in dramatically below the others doesn't signal efficiency. It signals that you either don't understand the scope or you're cutting corners somewhere. Agency producers who receive three bids ($195,000, $210,000, and $140,000) don't automatically award to the lowest number. They wonder what the $140,000 producer is planning to not do.

Your price is a statement about your judgment. Price yourself like you know what the job costs to do correctly.

THE ONE NUMBER YOU NEED BEFORE EVERY BID

Every time a bid request lands, before you build the budget, before you call the DP, before you open the template: know your MVR for this job.

What does this project actually need to generate to justify the weeks of prep, the shoot, the post, and the overhead it will absorb? Write it out:

- Direct costs: everything you'll pay out
- Markup on those costs: the company's revenue
- Director fee: your creative compensation

Now subtract your overhead allocation for the weeks this job runs. What's left is company profit. If company profit is near zero or negative, no amount of creative excitement changes the math. The directors who build sustainable companies are not the ones who win the most bids. They're the ones who understand the difference between a bid worth winning and a bid worth passing.

Section 5 covers agency relationships: how to get on the shortlist, stay there, and build the kind of recurring pipeline that makes the pricing conversations easier.

SECTION FIVE

Get in the Room

Agency Relationships, the Shortlist, and Building Recurring Pipeline

> *The client names, company names, and identifying details in this book have been changed to protect confidentiality. The situations, numbers, and outcomes are real.*

Nobody tells you that the hardest part of commercial production isn't directing. It's getting invited to bid in the first place. You can have a great reel, a real company, and real credits, and still be sitting home waiting for the phone to ring while agencies are sending RFPs to production companies they already know. That is not a talent problem. That is a pipeline problem.

This section is about how agency relationships actually work, how to get on the shortlists that generate bid invitations, what "keeping the relationship warm" actually means in practice, and when a sales rep makes sense vs. when you're not ready for one.

HOW AGENCIES FIND DIRECTORS

The short version is: they pull from what they already know. An agency producer who's been working in the industry for eight years has a mental roster of production companies they trust. When a new brief comes in, that mental roster is the first place they look. If your company isn't on it, you don't get the call.

The longer version involves several specific channels where discovery actually happens.

Shots Vault. Shots is an industry platform that agencies use to discover directors. The Vault subscription puts your director reels in front of agency producers and creative directors who are actively searching for talent. What we were buying wasn't immediate

jobs. We were buying discoverability with people who were not yet in our network. The honest assessment: it works slowly. You don't join and start getting calls. The platform is a long-game tool, not a lead generator.

Agency Access and similar platforms. These are subscription databases that give you contact information for agency producers and creative directors. Useful for cold outreach if you know how to do it. More useful once you have something specific to say.

Sales rep referrals. The most efficient path to an agency's shortlist is a warm introduction from a rep who already has that relationship. When a rep calls an agency producer they've worked with for years and says "I'm repping a director you should see," that call gets returned in a way that a cold email from the director doesn't.

Word of mouth within agencies. Commercial production is a small world. Agency producers talk to each other. A production company that does excellent work and is professional to work with gets talked about. Your reputation as an operator is a discovery channel whether you're managing it actively or not.

Cold outreach. Direct email to agency producers does work, but at a very low conversion rate. An email that says "we're a production company and would love to work with you" is deleted. An email that says "I'm the director who made [specific piece], and I saw your agency's recent work on [specific campaign] and I think we're fishing in similar creative water" is occasionally read.

GETTING ON THE SHORTLIST VS. JUST BEING A NAME THEY KNOW

Think about the shortlist in three levels.

Level one: they know you exist. Your reel has come across their desk at some point. At this level, you might get included in an RFP if the brief happens to match your category and they're having trouble filling out the bid list. This is not a position of real leverage.

Level two: they know your work. They've seen specific pieces. They have a category association. When a brief in that category comes in, your name surfaces in the internal conversation. This is where most production companies land after a few years of doing good work and putting it in front of the right people. It's a better position than level one but still not the shortlist.

Level three: they trust your company. This is where consistent bid invitations live. At level three, the agency producer includes you because not including you would require a reason. You're the expected call. Level three is built through completed work, reliable delivery, and the kind of relationship that survives the hard moments on a production.

The path from level two to level three almost always goes through actually doing a job together. Getting the first job with an agency is not primarily a creative competition. It's a risk-management calculation. The question they're answering when they include you in a bid isn't "are these the most talented people I could find?" It's "do I trust this company enough to recommend them to my client?"

THE REELS CONVERSATION

A creative director in a busy agency period may receive 20 or 30 director reels in a month. A reel gets 45 to 90 seconds of attention if it's good. It gets 15 seconds if it doesn't open strong. The agency producer is not sitting in a darkened room watching your full reel with an open mind. They're looking for a signal.

Open with the best thing you've ever made. Not the most recent, not the most technically impressive, not the one that shows your range, but the single piece that best represents what makes you worth hiring.

Keep the total reel under three minutes. A 90-second reel that's all strong is more powerful than a four-minute reel that has two strong things and two fillers.

Make specific reels for specific pitches. If you're pursuing food work with a particular agency, don't send them your full mixed reel. Send them a cut that leads with your two strongest food pieces. Specificity signals intention.

WHAT "KEEPING THE RELATIONSHIP WARM" ACTUALLY MEANS

Within 48 hours of any job wrapping, send a personal note to the agency producer and the creative director. Not a template. Something specific: a moment from the shoot that you're proud of, a specific decision the creative team made that you thought was right, something that shows you were paying attention to the work they cared about. This email takes five minutes. Most production companies don't send it. The ones who do are remembered.

Every six to eight weeks, share something real with agencies you want to stay in front of. A new piece of work. A project you just finished that fits a brief category they work in. An edit of a reel piece that's been sitting in your archive and is worth seeing. The rule is: it has to be something you'd actually want to show them, not a newsletter blast.

Once or twice a year, make an actual human connection. Coffee if you're in the same city. A call if you're not. Ask them what they're working on. Ask what kinds of briefs they're receiving that they're finding hard to cast. Listen. This is not a sales call. It's a professional relationship that you're choosing to invest in.

When something goes wrong, and things will go wrong, address it directly. An agency producer who hears about a problem from their client before they hear about it from you is unlikely to include you in the next bid. An agency producer who hears about a problem from you first, with a clear plan to solve it, is having a different conversation.

BUILDING RECURRING PIPELINE VS. ONE-SHOT TRANSACTIONS

There are two ways to run a commercial production company. You can chase individual jobs, respond to every RFP that comes in, win some, lose others, treat each one as a standalone transaction. Or you can build relationships that generate jobs predictably over time. The first model is exhausting and financially unpredictable. The second is what a sustainable company looks like.

Recurring pipeline comes from a small number of deep relationships, not a large number of shallow ones. Most boutique companies that have stable businesses are running on three to six agency relationships that generate consistent bid invitations. Those

relationships were built over years, through multiple jobs, and they produce work because the agency producers and creative directors know exactly what they're getting when they call.

The honest math on direct-to-brand vs. agency pipeline: direct-to-brand relationships are often more reliable month-to-month but lower ceiling. You know the client, you've built trust, they come back for more content. The budgets are usually smaller, typically $15,000 to $75,000 for most projects, but the relationship is simpler. A healthy boutique company uses direct-to-brand relationships as a base layer of revenue while building the agency relationships that unlock larger budgets.

THE SALES REP QUESTION

At some point in the development of a boutique production company, the question becomes: do we need a rep?

A sales rep in commercial production is a person or agency who represents your production company to advertising agencies. They make introduction calls, maintain relationships with agency producers and creative directors, and get your company considered for bid invitations that wouldn't have come otherwise. They operate on a percentage of the billings that come through their introductions. The standard structure: jobs that come through the rep's introductions are bid at a markup that accounts for the rep's percentage, with the rep's cut established through a separate agreement between the production company and the rep.

What a good rep actually does that you can't do yourself: they have existing relationships with agency producers that have been built over years. A rep who has placed production companies with a specific agency five times is going to get their calls returned. The same call from a production company the agency has never worked with is going to voicemail. The rep's value is access. They compress years of cold outreach into months of warm introductions.

What a rep cannot do: manufacture demand that isn't there. A rep can get your reel in front of the right people. They can't make a creative director want to hire you if the work doesn't connect. The reel has to earn the meeting. The rep gets you the meeting.

The decision to bring on a rep makes sense when three things are true. One, your reel is strong enough that once it's in front of the right people, it will generate real interest. Two, you've identified agencies whose work you want to be part of and whose creative territory aligns with yours. Three, you have enough production infrastructure to actually execute the jobs a rep will bring in.

Signing with a rep before the reel is ready is a mistake because you burn the relationship before it can generate anything. Reps have limited credibility with their agency contacts. They spend that credibility on introductions. If they introduce you to an agency producer and the reel doesn't land, they've used some of that credibility and generated nothing.

READING THE AGENCY: WHO DECIDES, WHO GATEKEEPS, WHAT THEY ACTUALLY CARE ABOUT

The decision-maker on whether to include you in a bid is usually the agency producer. They're the one whose operational judgment is on the line. Getting an agency producer to trust you is an operational argument: your company is professional, responsive, delivers what it bids, and doesn't create problems at wrap.

What agency producers actually care about, in order: reliability, communication, cost management, and creative quality. Not in that order if you're asking them directly. They'll say creative quality first, but in terms of what actually influences whether they recommend you for the next bid, reliability is the dominant variable. The director who delivered the job on time, hit the cost report within the holdback, and didn't create drama with the client is going to be called again before the more brilliant director who went three days over schedule and submitted a cost report six weeks after wrap.

What creative directors actually care about: a point of view. They're not looking for a director who can execute their vision technically. They're looking for a director who brings a perspective that elevates what they've written. The CDs who consistently hire the same boutique directors aren't doing it because those directors are technically flawless. They're doing it because working with those directors makes the brief better.

THE FIRST JOB DYNAMIC

The first job you do with a new agency is almost never the highest-stakes brief in their queue. It's the job where the risk feels manageable. A smaller scope. A brand that's not their most critical account. A brief where if you deliver competently but not brilliantly, the result is acceptable. Agencies don't hand a boutique director they've never worked with a $600,000 broadcast campaign on the first pass.

Your job on the first job is not to make the best work of your career. Your job is to demonstrate that working with you is low-friction, professional, and results in a delivered product that matches the treatment you pitched and the budget you bid. The treatment and the budget are promises. The first job is the proof that you keep your promises.

Specifically: communicate proactively. Don't make the agency producer chase you for updates. Deliver what you said you'd deliver. Submit the cost report within the agreed timeline. If something goes sideways during production, flag it before the agency producer hears about it from someone else. Be easy to work with.

> *A production company I'll call Fieldwork got their first bid invitation through a rep introduction. The brief was a $110,000 brand film for a regional health system. Not glamorous. But a real job with a real budget.*
>
> *On the job, two things went wrong. The locked location fell through four days before the shoot. The EP called the agency producer before 8 AM with two alternative locations already scouted, photos attached, rough cost comparisons included. She wasn't reporting a problem. She was presenting a solved problem. The cost report came in eleven business days after wrap.*
>
> *Nine weeks later, a new brief arrived. Bigger budget, more prominent client. The agency producer had mentioned Fieldwork to the creative director herself. Not because the work was exceptional. Because she'd said: "These people are easy." "Easy" is not a compliment about talent. It's a statement about risk. It means: if I put my professional judgment behind you and something goes wrong, I trust you to handle it in a way that doesn't come back on me.*

STAYING ON THE LIST WHEN THE WORK SLOWS DOWN

Commercial production is seasonal and lumpy. There are quarters where four jobs come in from the same agency in rapid succession, and there are quarters where nothing comes in and you're wondering if the relationship has stalled. Understanding the difference between a relationship that's genuinely stalling and a relationship that's just in a slow period is important, because the responses are different.

Agencies slow down for reasons that have nothing to do with you. Brand clients shift budgets. A major account moves to a competing agency. The creative team changes and the new team has their own preferred production companies. None of these are signals about your standing with the agency.

The signal that a relationship is genuinely stalling is different. You reach out and the agency producer doesn't respond over several weeks. You submit on a bid and hear nothing back. The creative director you had a relationship with has left and the new one has never heard of you.

> *A director I'll call Marcus did two jobs with a mid-size independent agency over the span of about a year. Both went well. After the second, the creative director told him directly: "We're going to be working together a lot." The next fourteen months were silence. Marcus sent two professional follow-up emails in that period, each with a new piece of work attached. Neither got a response. He'd written the relationship off when he sent one more email: direct, not pitching. "I've been trying to stay on your radar for over a year and I'm not sure if the fit still makes sense. Happy to talk if it does."*
>
> *The response came in four hours, from a producer he'd never heard of. The creative director Marcus had worked with had left the agency fourteen months earlier. The new producer had never heard of Marcus. The silence wasn't rejection. It was an empty inbox. What Marcus changed after that: every job, he made sure he knew at least two people inside the agency. Producer and CD at minimum. He also started doing a quick LinkedIn check on his agency contacts once a quarter.*

THE AGENCY RELATIONSHIP AT YEAR THREE

Here's what a well-functioning commercial pipeline looks like at year three for a boutique director-driven company that's done the relationship work.

Three to five agency relationships that generate two to four bid invitations per year each. Of those invitations, you're winning roughly 35 to 45 percent, the industry average for a competitive boutique company. That's eight to twelve agency jobs per year at this stage. Combined with a base of direct-to-brand relationships that provide two to five additional jobs, you're running a company that produces 10 to 17 jobs in a year. At an average of $75,000 to $150,000 per job, that's a real business.

The single thing that separates production companies that build recurring pipeline from the ones that stay stuck in the one-off transaction cycle: they invest in the relationship after the job, not just during the bid. The email you send 48 hours after wrap is what determines whether you get the next creative call.

Section 6 covers the full business operating system: when to hire, how the EP model works, what financial metrics actually matter, and how to scale without losing the qualities that made you good in the first place.

SECTION SIX

Built to Last

The Business Operating System for Independent Commercial Directors

> *The stories and scenarios in this section are composite illustrations drawn from real industry experiences. Names, companies, and identifying details have been changed.*

The commercial industry will give you great years and it will give you dead ones, and it will rarely tell you which kind you're in until it's already half over. The directors who build lasting companies aren't the ones with the best reels. Plenty of talented people have burned out or quietly gone back to day jobs. The ones still working after fifteen years figured out the financial structure, the pipeline discipline, and when to say no. That's what this section is about.

THE PRODUCTION COMPANY AS A BUSINESS (NOT JUST A PROJECT VEHICLE)

The director I'll call Elliot hit this wall at year three. He had just wrapped his fourth consecutive job in the $65,000 to $80,000 range. He was turning down smaller projects because he was too busy. His company had a name, a website, and a real reel. And he could not tell you what his company cost per month to keep open. That's the trap. You can be fully booked and technically insolvent at the same time if you don't know your overhead.

The actual business model for a commercial production company is this:

Revenue minus hard costs minus overhead equals company margin.

Most directors can tell you the first number. Some can approximate the second. Almost nobody tracks the third systematically until something goes wrong.

Here's what that looks like at a working boutique. Say your company does $420,000 in production revenue over a year. Hard costs on those jobs come to $310,000. That leaves $110,000 in gross margin. Your monthly overhead, including insurance, accounting, software, and a part-time coordinator, runs about $6,500 a month. Over twelve months that's $78,000. Your actual company margin is $32,000. Not $110,000. Not the gross margin. $32,000.

The directors who describe their finances as a blur of busy weeks and inexplicable empty bank accounts are almost always running what one forum commenter described with more precision than most industry consultants ever manage: "a project pipeline with a company name on it." That's not a company. That's a job you created for yourself with worse hours and no benefits.

Building a real company starts with one simple act: opening a spreadsheet and writing down every dollar that leaves the account when nobody is shooting. Do that once. Update it quarterly. Know your floor.

THE EP MODEL: WHAT EXECUTIVE PRODUCERS DO AND WHEN YOU NEED ONE

An EP's primary function is not producing. It's owning relationships and bringing in work.

The EP is the person whose phone calls get returned by agency producers. The person who has built enough trust with buyers over enough years that when they say "I have a director you should see," the meeting gets scheduled. The EP plays the long game with agencies on the company's behalf between jobs, pitches the company on briefs before those briefs are even formalized, and manages the pipeline so the phone doesn't go quiet for three months at a stretch.

If you have a senior person on staff who is exceptional at managing productions but hasn't built those agency relationships, they are a senior producer or a line producer. That is a different and valuable role. But giving them the EP title doesn't make them one.

The producing function and the business development function are not the same skill set. Someone who is brilliant at managing a shoot day may have no interest in relationship maintenance between jobs. Someone who is a natural relationship builder may be useless at managing a production schedule. The companies that confuse these roles end up overpaying for set work or underpaying for relationship capital.

The EP role becomes necessary when the director can no longer spend enough time on business development to maintain the pipeline. An EP who delivers real value typically structures their compensation at 10 to 25 percent of the fees they generate or oversee. The specific structure matters less than whether it's written down clearly before anyone does any work.

WHEN TO STAY LEAN AND WHEN TO HIRE

The rule I've made non-negotiable: you can justify a full-time hire when you are regularly turning down profitable work because you don't have the capacity to take it. Not when you're busy. When you're actively turning down work because you're out of capacity.

Production volume is episodic. Payroll is continuous. That asymmetry is what kills companies that hire too early. A full-time employee costs their salary during slow months too. The companies that build durable operating structures almost always share one characteristic: they keep fixed headcount low and maintain strong contractor relationships that allow them to scale capacity up and down with actual workload.

The hiring test: before adding anyone to fixed overhead, three questions. First: have we declined profitable work in the last three months specifically because we lacked the capacity to take it? Second: is the capacity problem a genuine production throughput issue, not a pipeline issue in disguise? Third: if next quarter comes in 40 percent lighter than this one, can we cover this salary without cutting something we shouldn't cut? If any of the three is no, the hire waits.

THE FINANCIAL METRICS THAT ACTUALLY MATTER FOR A PRODUCTION COMPANY

There are three numbers that determine whether a production company is healthy. Most owners track one of them fluently. The ones who track all three are the ones who stop being surprised by the results.

Number one: monthly overhead when nothing is shooting. This is your floor. Write down every recurring cost that doesn't go away between productions. Accounting fees, insurance premiums, software subscriptions, office costs, any fixed salaries, rep minimums, platform subscriptions, phone lines. Add them up per month. That number is what you need to generate in company margin every single month just to stay in business.

Number two: utilization rate. This is billable days divided by available days. Below 40 percent is a pipeline problem. You don't have enough incoming work to keep the company meaningfully busy, and overhead keeps running regardless. Above 80 percent is a different problem: you're either underpriced, under-resourced, or both. The healthy operating range is roughly 50 to 75 percent. Track this monthly. If it slips below 50 percent for two consecutive months, that's the moment to activate your pipeline, not to wait and hope the next quarter corrects it.

Number three: company margin percentage. Take the revenue from a job. Subtract the hard costs. What's left is gross margin. Now subtract the overhead allocated to that period. What's left is actual company margin. The number most directors confuse with margin is the production markup. The markup has to cover your actual overhead before a single dollar becomes profit. If your markup is 20 percent and your overhead consumes 17 points of it, your actual margin is 3 percent. A company that consistently margins 8 to 12 percent after overhead is in a categorically different position than one that consistently margins 2 to 4 percent.

Track all three numbers. Know your floor. Know your utilization. Know your margin per job, not just per line item in the bid.

BUILDING YOUR ROSTER: ADDING DIRECTORS WITHOUT LOSING YOUR IDENTITY

Adding a director to your roster is a bet. You're betting your agency relationships, your EP's time, and your rep's credibility on this person's ability to win pitches and execute. Here are the three questions I ask before adding anyone to the Farallon roster.

One: does this director's reel open doors that our current reel doesn't? The test is not whether they're talented. The test is whether their work puts us in front of brief categories we're currently not getting called on. If two directors on your roster could both plausibly win the same brief, you've split your own pitch resources without adding capability.

Two: is there enough volume in your brief flow that this director won't starve? A director who joins your roster and doesn't work will leave. Before making the commitment, do an honest assessment of your current agency relationships and the brief types they generate. The roster decision has to be based on what your pipeline actually generates, not on what you hope your pipeline will generate once the right director is attached.

Three: can this relationship sustain the revenue-split conversation? The director-production company arrangement involves real money flowing to the company for the infrastructure, EP time, and rep relationships the director benefits from. The split varies by arrangement, but the conversation has to happen before the first job. Directors who experience the split as a toll rather than a fair exchange for genuine value tend to work their way out of the arrangement within a year or two.

One thing that rarely gets said clearly: removing a director who isn't working is harder than not adding them in the first place. The best moment to think clearly about fit is before the roster commitment, not after eighteen months of minimal production.

WORKING WITH SALES REPS: HOW TO STRUCTURE THE RELATIONSHIP FOR MAXIMUM RETURN

A sales rep is the highest-leverage external relationship available to a boutique production company. A good rep with genuine agency connections can put you in front of creative directors you've never been able to reach through any amount of cold outreach.

Here's the structural problem that quietly kills most production company-rep relationships. Both parties treat it as passive. The production company signs with the rep, sends updated materials, and waits for calls to come in. The rep adds the company to their roster, makes some introductions, and waits for pitches to land. Neither party invests in the relationship between those events.

> *A director I'll call Cara ran a boutique company in the Pacific Northwest with a strong lifestyle and outdoor brand reel. She signed with a rep I'll call Renata, who had strong connections at mid-size agencies in Chicago and Seattle. The first six months were productive. Two jobs came through. Both went well. Then things slowed down. Cara assumed Renata was working her agency relationships on Cara's behalf. Renata assumed that when a relevant brief appeared, Cara would reach out. Nothing happened for four months.*
>
> *When Cara finally called to check in, the problem clarified immediately. Renata had three other companies on her roster. Two of them had been sending updated reel cuts and reaching out monthly. Cara's company had gone silent, and silent gets deprioritized. What Cara changed: she scheduled a standing monthly check-in with Renata. Not to pitch a specific brief. Just to stay in Renata's operational thinking. She started sending reel updates whenever she finished a new piece. The volume of agency calls through Renata increased meaningfully within a quarter. Not because the reel had changed. Because Renata was actually thinking about Cara's company when briefs crossed her desk.*

A rep relationship is a partnership, and partnerships require both parties to maintain them. Check in at least once a month. Share something real each time. Make it easy for the rep to advocate for you. Stay visible.

THE FEAST-OR-FAMINE PROBLEM AND HOW TO SOLVE IT

The feast-or-famine cycle in commercial production is not a hustle problem. It's a revenue structure problem. Here are the three structural moves that actually work.

Direct-to-brand relationships as a base layer. Agency work comes with a procurement layer, a competitive bid process, and a timeline largely outside your control. Direct-to-brand work skips most of that. A regional brand that retains your company for quarterly content at $18,000 per quarter is generating $72,000 a year that arrives on a schedule. That's a floor that makes the gap between agency jobs survivable.

Editorial and finishing revenue. If your company has post-production capability, there is a version of this business where you're providing ongoing finishing services to brands or agencies in your network at a monthly rate. Not becoming a post house. Using capability you already have to create a revenue stream that doesn't require winning a bid.

The 90-day rolling pipeline review. On the first week of every month, sit down and look clearly at what's confirmed in the next 90 days. Not hopeful. Not "in conversation about." Confirmed jobs only, meaning signed agreements or at minimum cost-confirmed briefs. If the 90-day forward view shows a gap, that's the moment to activate the pipeline. Directors who get blindsided by slow periods almost always saw the signal early and didn't act on it.

At Farallon, I keep a cash reserve equivalent to roughly three months of overhead. That didn't happen quickly. It built over years as a deliberate policy of not reinvesting margin into growth until the floor was stable. It's the most important structural decision I've made as a business owner. I don't quote from desperation. I'm not pricing work low because I need the job. I'm pricing work based on what it actually costs to do it well, from a position that can absorb a no.

WHAT SUSTAINABLE LOOKS LIKE: DEFINING SUCCESS ON YOUR OWN TERMS

I want to close this section by being direct about something the commercial production world rarely says clearly. The metrics the industry publicly values are not the ones that tell you whether you've built something worth having. Award wins. Roster size. Recognizable brand names in your credits. The volume of bids you're invited into. These are signals of visibility. They're not signals of sustainability.

Sustainability looks different for different people, and that's not a philosophical dodge. It's genuinely true. Some directors want a company of eight people running at the highest levels of commercial production. Some want to stay lean, preserve creative control, and make work they're proud of for clients who respect the process. Both are legitimate models. The mistake is optimizing for the version that looks impressive to the industry rather than the one that fits the life you're actually trying to build.

Here's what the honest definition of sustainable looks like, stripped of the industry-image layer. You know your overhead. You're covering it every month without drama. You have a cash reserve that lets you say no to work that's wrong for you without panic. You're generating enough margin that a slow quarter feels like a slow quarter, not a threat. Your pipeline has enough depth that you're not waking up at 3 AM doing math on worst-case scenarios. You're making work that represents your actual point of view, not work you took because you needed the check.

None of those criteria require fame. They require knowing your numbers, building relationships with intention, making hard calls before they become expensive ones, and being honest with yourself about the difference between a business that looks successful and a business that is sustainable.

The boring operational discipline is what protects the creative work. The spreadsheets, the overhead tracking, the pipeline reviews, the monthly rep calls. None of that is why you became a director. But it is why you get to keep directing.

You can only keep taking the jobs you want to take if the company is solvent enough to decline the jobs you don't. You can only decline the wrong jobs if you're not desperate. You can only avoid desperation if the floor is solid. The floor is built from everything in this section. The directors who are still working in fifteen years built that floor early. It's a less romantic version of the story than most directors want to tell about themselves. It's also the one that ends with them still directing.

APPENDIX A

The Commercial Bid Template

AICP Format Reference

The AICP bid format is the universal standard for commercial production budgets in the United States. The following template represents a representative mid-size production budget (two shoot days, one primary location, SAG-AFTRA talent). All figures are sample estimates for reference; actual costs will vary by market, scope, and crew.

> ***How to use this template:*** *Fill in your actual crew rates, rental quotes, and vendor bids for each line item. Apply fringes (typically 28-33% on union crew wages, 12-15% on non-union) to all labor. Calculate markup on the total of all direct costs. Add contingency last.*

LINE ITEM	DAYS / UNITS	RATE	TOTAL
SECTION A: PRE-PRODUCTION & WRAP (CREW LABOR)			
Director (Prep Days)	5 days	$1,500/day	$7,500
Producer / Line Producer (Prep)	8 days	$1,200/day	$9,600
Production Coordinator (Prep)	8 days	$650/day	$5,200
Art Director (Prep)	4 days	$900/day	$3,600
Wardrobe Stylist (Shopping/Prep)	3 days	$750/day	$2,250
Producer Wrap Days	3 days	$1,200/day	$3,600
Fringes on Section A Labor (28%)			$8,904
SECTION B: SHOOTING CREW			
Director of Photography	2 days	$2,400/day	$4,800
1st Assistant Director	2 days	$1,400/day	$2,800
1st Assistant Camera	2 days	$950/day	$1,900
2nd Assistant Camera	2 days	$600/day	$1,200
Gaffer	2 days	$1,100/day	$2,200
Best Boy Electric	2 days	$750/day	$1,500
Electrician (x2)	2 days each	$500/day	$2,000
Key Grip	2 days	$1,000/day	$2,000
Best Boy Grip	2 days	$700/day	$1,400
Production Sound Mixer	2 days	$1,100/day	$2,200
Boom Operator	2 days	$550/day	$1,100
Hair & Makeup Artist	2 days	$750/day	$1,500
Wardrobe Stylist (Shoot Days)	2 days	$750/day	$1,500
Production Manager (Shoot Days)	2 days	$1,000/day	$2,000
Production Coordinator (Shoot Days)	2 days	$650/day	$1,300
Production Assistants (x3)	2 days each	$325/day	$1,950

LINE ITEM	DAYS / UNITS	RATE	TOTAL
Kit Fees (Gaffer, Sound, Key Grip)	2 days	$350/day est.	$700
Fringes on Section B Labor (28%)			$9,632
SECTION C: LOCATION & TRAVEL			
Location Fee (Primary Location, 2 days)	2 days	$3,500/day	$7,000
Location Scout / Manager	3 days	$900/day	$2,700
Filming Permits			$600
Parking (2 shoot days)			$800
Mileage & Production Transport			$400
SECTION D: PROPS, WARDROBE & SPECIAL ITEMS			
Props (Purchase & Rental)			$2,200
Wardrobe (Purchase, Rentals)			$1,800
Wardrobe & HMU Expendables			$400
SECTION E: STUDIO & EQUIPMENT			
Camera Package (Body + Lenses)	2 days	$2,800/day	$5,600
Lighting & Grip Package	2 days	$1,800/day	$3,600
Playback / Video Village	2 days	$350/day	$700
Walkie Talkies	2 days	$300/day	$600
Generator (if needed)	2 days	$500/day	$1,000
SECTION F: FILM, MEDIA & DATA			
Camera Media (Cards)			$400
Data Management / Backup Drives			$600
SECTION G: MISCELLANEOUS			
Craft Service (2 shoot days, 20 people)			$800
Catering (Breakfast & Lunch, 2 days, 20 people)			$2,400

LINE ITEM	DAYS / UNITS	RATE	TOTAL
Office / Administrative Expenses			$350
Production Expendables			$300
SECTION H: DIRECTOR / CREATIVE FEES			
Director's Creative Fee (Flat)			$12,000
Executive Producer Fee			$4,500
SECTION I: TALENT			
Principal Talent (x2, Session Fee, SAG-AFTRA Scale)	2 sessions	$965/ session	$1,930
Talent Agent Commission (10%)			$193
SAG-AFTRA P&H Contributions (~19%)			$367
Background / Extras (x4)	2 days each	$200/day	$1,600
Casting Director Fee			$1,800
SECTION J: INSURANCE			
General Liability Insurance			$650
Equipment Insurance (Inland Marine)			$350
POST-PRODUCTION			
Editorial (Offline + Online)			$6,500
Color Grade			$2,800
Sound Mix & Audio Finishing			$1,800
Music License (Stock/Library)			$800
Graphics / Motion Titles			$1,200
Deliverables & Encoding (Master + Social Cuts)			$600
TOTAL DIRECT COSTS			**$135,225**
Production Markup (20% on Direct Costs)			$27,045
Contingency (7%)			$9,466

LINE ITEM	DAYS / UNITS	RATE	TOTAL
TOTAL BID			**$171,736**

> ***Note on fringes:*** *Fringe rates above (28%) represent a blended estimate for non-union production including employer payroll taxes, workers' comp, and payroll service fees. Union (SAG-AFTRA, IATSE) productions will have different fringe structures. Always confirm fringe rates with your payroll company before finalizing any bid.*
>
> ***Note on markup:*** *The 20% markup shown here is within standard commercial range. On smaller budgets, 22-25% is appropriate. On larger budgets ($250K+), 15-18% is more common. Your markup must cover operating overhead not captured in direct costs.*

APPENDIX B

The Director's Treatment Outline Template

A Structural Guide for Writing Treatments That Win

The following outline represents the ideal structure for a commercial director's treatment. This is not a rigid template; adapt it to the specific brief and your own directorial voice. The order of sections matters. Concept before execution. Feeling before technical detail.

Target length: 8 to 14 pages including visual references. Adjust for scope: shorter for 15-30 second spots, longer for brand films and multi-spot campaigns.

> **01. TITLE PAGE**
>
> - Production company name and director name
> - Project title and brand
> - Agency name and date submitted
> - Brief identifying mark (version, confidential notice if required)
>
> **02. CONCEPT STATEMENT (1-2 PARAGRAPHS)**
>
> *The most important section. What is this spot really about? Not the script's surface content, but the human truth underneath. This section should make the CD feel understood.*
>
> - Begin with the emotional core, not the execution
> - Use language from the creative call if possible (a specific phrase the team used)
> - State the human truth the spot is reaching for
> - Connect that truth directly to the brand's objective
> - Do NOT summarize the script here
>
> **03. DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT (0.5-1 PAGE)**

Your personal connection to the material. Why this story matters to you specifically. This is where the agency learns who you are as a person, not just as a service provider.

- Write in first person
- Include a specific, personal memory or observation that connects to the brief
- Explain your directorial approach to this particular emotional territory
- Avoid generic enthusiasm; make it specific and honest
- Length: 150-250 words is ideal

04. TONE & WORLD (1 PAGE)

How should the spot feel? This is emotional, not technical. Describe the experience of watching it, not the camera specifications.

- 3-5 adjectives or short phrases that define the emotional register
- Describe pacing and rhythm (not shot count)
- Address the relationship between the viewer and the subject
- Name the feeling you want the viewer to carry out of the 30-60 seconds

05. VISUAL REFERENCES (1-2 PAGES)

3-8 images maximum. Each image should be curated, not collected. One sentence per image explaining exactly what you're taking from it. Pull from outside the category when possible.

- Images should be cohesive, not comprehensive
- Include a caption for each: "This is the quality of light in the interior scenes"
- Reference film, photography, or art rather than other commercials where possible
- The images together should tell a coherent visual story
- Keep file size manageable: compress to screen resolution

06. SCENE APPROACH / SCRIPT INTERPRETATION (1-3 PAGES)

For each major scene or beat in the script, a brief directorial note. This is not a shot list. It is a description of the feeling and approach for each moment.

- 1-3 sentences per scene maximum
- Focus on the emotional truth of each moment, not the blocking
- Highlight any scenes where your interpretation diverges from the literal script
- Note specific performance direction that's central to your approach

07. CASTING DIRECTION (0.5 PAGE)

Who is in front of the camera? Be specific. Casting direction reveals that you've thought about where the emotional life of the spot actually lives.

- Age range, general description, type (actor vs. non-actor, etc.)
- Ethnicity and diversity considerations if relevant to the brief
- The quality you're looking for (weathered, natural, urban, etc.)
- Any specific notes on performance style (naturalistic, heightened, etc.)

08. LOCATION APPROACH (0.5 PAGE)

Where does this spot live? Real locations vs. constructed sets. Practical light vs. controlled lighting. Time of day. Season.

- General location types, not specific addresses at bid stage
- What the location needs to contribute to the emotional world
- Any geographic or regional considerations
- Interior vs. exterior balance

09. TECHNICAL APPROACH (OPTIONAL, 0.5-1 PAGE)

Camera, lenses, movement approach. Include only if it's essential to the creative vision and not already clear from the visual references. Do not lead with this.

- Camera system preference if it matters creatively
- Lens choice and what it contributes to the look
- Movement philosophy (handheld, static, observational, etc.)
- Any specific visual techniques that serve the concept

10. CLOSING PARAGRAPH

One final paragraph. Restate why this brief matters and what you're bringing to it. This is your last word before the agency makes their decision. Make it land.

- Connect back to the concept from the opening
- Avoid generic closes ("I'm excited to bring this to life")
- End with conviction, not hedging

Common mistakes to avoid in every treatment: *Opening with camera specs or mood boards before establishing concept. Restating the brief verbatim. Including more than 8 visual references. Using the phrase "authentic storytelling" without specificity. Submitting more than 14 pages for a 30-60 second spot. Missing the deadline.*

APPENDIX C

Agency Outreach Email Templates

Three Templates for Different Relationship Stages

The following templates are starting points, not scripts. Customize every email with specific details about the agency's recent work and your actual reel. A generic version of any of these templates will not perform. An email that shows you've actually watched the agency's work and have a real point of view is the only version worth sending.

Keep all introductory emails short: under 200 words. Agency producers are moving fast. The goal of the first email is a reply, not a sale. Attachments are acceptable if small (reel link preferred over file attachment). Never attach a full treatment unsolicited.

TEMPLATE 1: INITIAL COLD OUTREACH TO AGENCY PRODUCER

Subject: [Director Name] / [Production Company] - Reel Introduction

To: Agency Producer

Hi [Name],

I'm [Director Name], the director at [Production Company]. I've been following [Agency Name]'s work - the [specific recent campaign] caught my attention, particularly the [specific thing you actually noticed: a casting choice, a creative approach, a tone]. That kind of [quality you observed] is territory I work in pretty naturally.

We recently finished [specific relevant piece that fits their brief category] for [brand or category], which I think lines up with the work you're doing. Reel here: [link].

Would it make sense to get 20 minutes on the phone when you have a brief that fits this lane? Happy to send more work in the meantime.

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] | [Website] | [Phone]

> ***Notes on this template:*** *The specific observation about their work is the most important sentence. Do not use generic compliments like "I really admire your work." Name a specific piece and say specifically what you noticed. This signals that you've actually watched it. The reel link goes in the email body, not as an attachment. Follow up once after 10-14 business days if no response; then let it rest for 6-8 weeks before trying again.*

TEMPLATE 2: POST-LOSS FOLLOW-UP (KEEPING THE DOOR OPEN)

Subject: Re: [Project Name] - Thanks for the invitation

To: Agency Producer (and optionally, Creative Director)

Hi [Name],

Thank you for including us in the [Project Name] bid. We genuinely enjoyed working through that brief - it's good territory for us and we put real thought into the treatment.

Whoever you awarded it to, I hope the production goes smoothly. We'd love to be in the mix on a future brief when the timing is right. We're particularly well-suited for [category you want more of: e.g., "real-people-driven work" or "food and lifestyle content"].

Thanks again,
[Name]
[Company] | [Website]

> ***Notes on this template:*** *Send this within 48 hours of receiving the pass. Keep it short - two short paragraphs maximum. The goal is to close the loop gracefully and leave a professional impression. Most directors go silent after a loss. The ones who send a note like this are remembered. Do not ask why you didn't win, ask for feedback, or express disappointment. This is not the place for that conversation.*

TEMPLATE 3: NEW WORK SHARE (STAYING TOP OF MIND WITH EXISTING CONTACTS)

Subject: New work from [Production Company] - [Category / Brief Description]

To: Agency Producer or Creative Director (existing contact)

Hi [Name],

We just finished this [brand film / campaign / product spot] for [brand/category] and I wanted to share it with you. It's right in the lane we've been talking about - [specific quality: "documentary-style work with real people" / "high-end lifestyle content" / etc.].

Link: [Vimeo or website link]

I'll keep you posted when we have more in this category. And if anything comes across your desk that seems like a fit, I'd love to be in the conversation.

Thanks,
[Name]

> ***Notes on this template:*** *Send this every 6-8 weeks if you have genuinely new work to share. Do not send a version of this email if you don't have something new and relevant. The goal is to stay in the agency producer's peripheral vision as a company that is active and producing. If you don't have new production work, you can occasionally send a note sharing a piece of work you found interesting (another director's film, a campaign you thought was strong) with a brief thought on why. This signals that you're engaged with the industry, not just pitching yourself.*

All three templates are starting points. The specific details you add, the observation about their recent work, the honest description of what you just made, the genuine interest in a specific category of brief, are what make them land. Generic emails get deleted. Specific ones get read.

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